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Principles and Interests

A DAY BEFORE Independence, on 14 August 1947, the president of India's Constituent Assembly, Rajendra Prasad, declared that India had 'a great part to play in the shaping and moulding of the future of a war distracted world'. It could play that part, he said, 'not by mimicking, from a distance, what others are doing, or by joining in the race for armaments and competing with others in the discovery of the latest and most effective instruments of destruction'. As an independent country, India now had the opportunity and Prasad expressed the hope that it would have 'the courage and strength to place before the world' an 'infallible substitute for war and bloodshed, death and destruction'.[1] Prasad became the first president of the Republic of India, serving from 1949 to 1962. His independence-eve declaration reflected values that have resonated in India's interaction with the rest of the world.

In the view of most Indians, their fervent desire to safeguard independence and autonomy of decision making is the most significant principle underlying their country's foreign policy. The colonial experience has left an indelible mark on India's collective personality. More than six decades after Independence, seeking freedom from external pressures is as much at the core of India's external relations as it was when India was a